HOSPITALITY RELATED INVESTMENTS IN POST-CONFLICT RECONSTRUCTION

The Case for Agri-Food and Logistics Investment in Ukraine as a Strategic Opportunity for the Hospitality Sector

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I. INTRODUCTION

Hospitality depends on agriculture, though in peacetime, when supply chains run smoothly and investors chase consumer-facing returns, few look that far down the chain. Post-conflict reconstruction brings the dependence into view and opens investment opportunities.

Most people assume geopolitical instability is bad for hospitality. For hotels and tourism, that is correct. But hospitality is a much broader sector than that. It includes food production, processing, cold chain logistics, mass catering, and supply chain infrastructure. These activities are the core of the industry rather than a supporting layer, and they behave very differently from the consumer-facing side. COVID-19 made this visible: hotels and restaurants were among the first things to close, while food supply chains kept running throughout. Post-conflict markets follow the same logic. While destruction removes much of the consumer-facing sector, it also creates immediate demand for the essential parts of the system such as food supply and logistics.

The global travel and tourism sector contributed around $10 trillion to world GDP in 2023, about 9.1% of the global economy (WTTC, 2024). Tourism statistics do not separate out the food and logistics layer beneath that figure, and that layer is the subject of this paper. The paper makes the case that Ukraine's reconstruction is a specific, time-limited opportunity for companies operating in that segment, and that the opportunity depends on how the war ends. It examines the historical pattern, Ukraine's situation in detail, the concrete opportunity, the financing mechanisms available, the risks that actually matter, and what the same pattern looks like in other markets.

Large operators are more exposed than they look. A large hotel group running properties across Europe or the Middle East sources tens of thousands of tonnes of food annually through centralised procurement systems. Airline caterers, institutional food service operators, and cruise lines all depend on cold-chain infrastructure and grain supply at volumes that make them directly exposed to regional agricultural disruptions. When Russia blockaded Ukraine's Black Sea ports in 2022, and again when it ended the Black Sea Grain Initiative in July 2023, these were not abstract events for commodity traders. They fed into procurement costs for hospitality operators who had built their cost structures around stable Black Sea supply. Those operators now have a reason to invest in the infrastructure behind that supply.

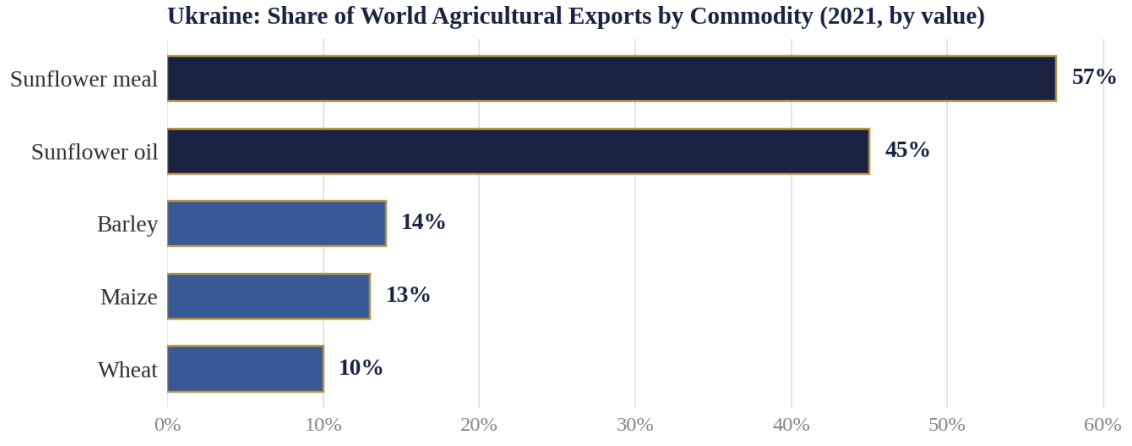


Figure 1: Ukraine's share of world exports by commodity, 2021, by trade value. Source: Grant et al., Choices (AAEA, 2022). Other sources (FAO, USDA, World Economic Forum) put individual shares one to three points higher or lower, depending on year and on value versus volume. These figures illustrate the scale of supply-chain exposure for the global hospitality sector.

II. THE DESTRUCTION-RECONSTRUCTION CYCLE

Large-scale conflict destroys old infrastructure, and rebuilding can bring faster modernisation. Economists dispute how far this holds, and nothing about the destruction is worth celebrating. When an entire road network, rail system, or set of factories is destroyed or made obsolete, the country rebuilding it does not have to work around what was already there. It can build with current technology and current standards, backed by foreign capital that would not have arrived in peacetime. Economic historians describe postwar Europe's rapid growth as a process of catch-up towards the technological frontier (Abramovitz, 1986; Eichengreen, 2007).

The Marshall Plan is the most obvious reference. Between 1948 and 1952 the United States committed around $13.3 billion, roughly $180 billion in today's money (CPI-adjusted), to rebuild Western Europe after World War II. West Germany grew at about 8% a year between 1950 and 1960, and Germans called it the Wirtschaftswunder, the economic miracle. Historians disagree about how much of that came from Marshall aid. Most West German industrial capacity had in fact survived the bombing, and much of the recovery came from restored productivity and market reform, with US-funded counterpart funds helping to ease bottlenecks in coal, steel and transport (Eichengreen and Ritschl, 2008; Ritschl, EH.Net).

A smaller version of the pattern followed the collapse of the Soviet Union. Poland, the Czech Republic, and the Baltic states entered the 1990s with Soviet-era infrastructure that was inefficient and outdated. EU accession brought structural funds and foreign investment. In Poland, large multinationals were active from the very beginning of privatisation, including Coca-Cola, Nestlé, PepsiCo, Unilever and Danone, and foreign owners now hold more than 70% of confectionery production (USDA FAS, 2016). Poland's food processing sector went from a struggling post-communist industry to one of the more competitive in Europe within two decades, and the early entrants built positions that outlasted the transition.

Ukraine may be entering a similar moment. International financing is already being mobilised, and the country's agricultural potential is far greater than Poland's was in the 1990s. The difference is that the war has not ended, which changes how much of the pattern can be relied on.

III. UKRAINE AS THE PRIMARY CASE

Before the full-scale Russian invasion of February 2022, Ukraine was already one of the most important agricultural countries in the world. It was the largest exporter of sunflower oil globally and ranked among the top five exporters of both maize and wheat, with about 10% of global wheat exports and 13% of maize by value in 2021 (rankings vary by measure). The country has around 41 million hectares of agricultural land, of which about 33 million are arable (EPRS, 2024). Chernozem, black earth soil that is among the most fertile in the world, covers roughly half of its territory.

The infrastructure side of the picture was much weaker. Ukraine's roads, rail, cold chain logistics, and food processing facilities were largely Soviet in design and had not received serious investment since independence. In 2023 the country ranked 79th of 139 economies on the World Bank's Logistics Performance Index, with a score of 2.7, against 3.2 for Romania and Bulgaria and 3.6 for Poland (World Bank, 2023). Port infrastructure at Odesa had not been modernised to the level its export volumes required, and inland logistics costs were high relative to cargo volume.

The war hit global commodity markets at once. Chicago wheat futures rose about 41% in the first week of March 2022 and reached a record $13.64 a bushel on March 8, and the FAO's vegetable oil price index rose 23% in March 2022 alone (Farm Policy News, 2022; FAO, 2022). For the hospitality sector this was a direct cost shock to food procurement budgets across every segment from hotels to institutional catering. WFP and FAO projected in March 2022 that the war could push an additional 33 to 47 million people into acute food insecurity, depending on how long it lasted. Russia blockaded Ukraine's Black Sea ports for about five months, until the UN- and Turkey-brokered Black Sea Grain Initiative was signed on July 22, 2022. Russia withdrew on July 17, 2023, after some 25 to 33 million tonnes had shipped (Council of the EU), and Ukraine then opened its own corridor in August 2023. WFP's executive director has said Ukraine alone feeds 400 million people, a rhetorical estimate rather than a measured one. Even so, the point stands that global hospitality supply chains depend heavily on Ukrainian agricultural production, and that rebuilding that system is a food security priority for the sector as well as an investment opportunity.

The war also made Ukraine's infrastructure deficit far worse. The World Bank's fifth Rapid Damage and Needs Assessment (RDNA5, February 2026) put ten-year recovery and reconstruction needs at $588 billion, up from $486 billion in the third assessment (2024). Transport is the largest single need at $96 billion, followed by energy ($91 billion), housing ($90 billion), commerce and industry ($63 billion) and agriculture ($55 billion). These are estimates of need, not money pledged. On the funding side, the EU committed a Ukraine Facility of €50 billion for 2024 to 2027, and agreed a further €90 billion loan for 2026 and 2027, split between budget support and defence. The G7 and multilateral development banks have added to that. Because transport ranks first and agriculture fifth, the logistics half of this paper's case rests on firmer ground in the numbers than the agriculture half.

EU accession matters as well. Ukraine was granted EU candidate status in June 2022, formal accession negotiations opened in June 2024, and the first negotiating cluster opened on June 15, 2026. Hungary again blocked the next screening results on September 1, 2026, so the timeline remains uncertain. Even at this stage, accession brings regulatory alignment, access to structural funds, and a legal framework that lowers the risk premium for foreign investors. Whatever happens with the war's territorial outcome, Ukraine is likely to come out of it more aligned with the EU and the West than it has ever been, and that strengthens the case for investors.

IV. THE AGRI-FOOD OPPORTUNITY

The hospitality opportunity in Ukraine right now is not about hotels. Nobody is building a luxury resort in Kharkiv. The opportunity is in food, through three channels that reinforce each other.

The first is agri-food processing. Ukraine exports most of its agricultural output as raw commodities: grain, oilseeds, unprocessed produce. The layer that turns those inputs into packaged food, ready meals, and branded products is thin. Soviet-era agriculture was designed to produce at volume and export raw, not to add value domestically. Reconstruction is the moment to build that layer to EU standards, with modern facilities. Building costs are likely to be lower now than once reconstruction normalises and land and construction prices recover, so companies that move in the next two to three years may build at a lower cost than those that wait.

The second is logistics. Ukraine's geography is exceptional. It sits between Europe, the Middle East, and Central Asian trade routes, with rail connections into the EU network and access to the Black Sea through Odesa and the Danube ports. The constraint has been infrastructure rather than location, and the 2026 strikes

have tested that gap directly. In July and August 2026 Russian strikes on Odesa-region ports cut vessel arrivals sharply, shipowners suspended calls, and Reuters reported that about 30 million tonnes of grain and oilseeds, roughly half the forecast, could go unexported. Alternative routes carry only about half of port capacity and add $45 to $50 a tonne (Reuters via Baird Maritime, 2026). This paper's view is that the case for logistics investment is stronger for it, but the sequencing has changed. The first investable assets are the routes that do not depend on Odesa: Danube ports, rail conversion at the Polish and Romanian borders, and inland distribution capacity. Deep-water port upgrades come after the security situation allows them. A modernised Ukrainian logistics hub would still be one of the best-positioned supply chain nodes in the Eurasian network, and hospitality groups sourcing food at scale for European or Middle Eastern operations would benefit directly.

The third is institutional catering. Reconstruction generates large-scale demand for organised food service. Hundreds of thousands of construction workers, military personnel, humanitarian workers, and returning civilians all need feeding every day. Iraq showed how such demand is served: military logistics and catering there ran for years under the LOGCAP III contract, whose value reached about $35.7 billion, and went to a large operator with existing government contracting capability (CRS, 2010). The window to position for comparable contracts in Ukraine is before a ceasefire, not after it.

Market	Agricultural Base	Reconstruction Financing	EU/Western Alignment	Entry Window	Primary Opportunity
Ukraine (2026)	**Exceptional (top-5 exporter of key grains)**	**$588bn estimated needs (World Bank, 2026)**	**EU candidate since 2022; talks opened 2024**	**Open, but war continues**	**Processing, logistics, catering**
Iraq (post-2003)	Limited	~$60bn (US appropriations, SIGIR)	Low	2004-2008 (missed by most)	Mass catering, fuel logistics
Poland (post-1991)	Strong	EU structural funds	Applied 1994, joined 2004	1992-1998 (early entrants)	Food processing, distribution
Bosnia (post-1995)	Moderate	~$5.1bn (World Bank, EC and EBRD est. programme cost, 1996-99)	Applied 2016; candidate since 2022	1996-2002	Catering, basic logistics

Table 1: Comparative Post-Conflict Investment Overview, Hospitality and Food Sector. Sources: World Bank (2026); SIGIR (2013); World Bank, EC and EBRD (1996); EEAS; Council of the EU.

Ukraine combines the strongest agricultural base of any post-conflict market in recent history with the largest estimated reconstruction need and the most direct Western alignment. Poland in the early 1990s is the closest historical analogue, and the multinationals that entered its food sector early built positions that shaped the market for the following two decades. The entry window in Ukraine is open, but it is narrower than it looked a year ago, because the war continues and the deep-water ports are under attack.

V. HOW THE MONEY FLOWS: FINANCING MECHANISMS

Identifying $588 billion of reconstruction needs does not show a company where the money is or how to reach it. Five channels matter to hospitality sector investors, and they differ in access, conditions and risk.

Financing Vehicle	Provider	Instrument	Sector Relevance	Key Condition
Ukraine Facility (€50bn, 2024-27)	European Union	Grants + concessional loans to Ukraine govt	Agri-food, logistics, energy infrastructure	Governance reform benchmarks
Ukraine Investment Framework (within the Facility)	EU with EBRD, EIB and other partners	Guarantees + grants for private investors (€9.6bn; aims to mobilise up to €40bn)	Food supply chains, logistics hubs	Applied for through partner institutions
EBRD Project Financing	European Bank for Reconstruction & Development	Direct loans to private sector	Food processing, cold chain, logistics	EBRD environmental and social standards
DFC guarantees and US-Ukraine Reconstruction Investment Fund	US Development Finance Corporation	Political risk insurance, loan guarantees; $150m initial capital ($75m DFC seed plus $75m from Ukraine), 2025	Energy, infrastructure, minerals, dual-use industry, transport and logistics (agri-food not yet named)	US-linked entity or partnership
World Bank Group	IBRD / IDA / IFC / MIGA	Project financing, investment, political risk guarantees	Infrastructure, agri-food systems	Competitive procurement for public projects

Table 2: Key Reconstruction Financing Vehicles, Hospitality and Agri-Food Sector. Sources: European Commission; DFC (2025, 2026); EBRD; World Bank.

The most accessible entry point for a private hospitality sector company is EBRD project financing combined with EU guarantees under the Ukraine Investment Framework. The EBRD has a long track record of lending directly to food processing and logistics projects in Eastern Europe, has committed more than €10.5 billion to Ukraine since 2022, and its standards align with what companies should be building to anyway for accession alignment. DFC guarantees are particularly relevant for US-linked investors, since political risk insurance addresses the most difficult constraint in the Ukraine investment case. The US-Ukraine Reconstruction Investment Fund is worth watching, but its stated priorities are energy, infrastructure, critical minerals, dual-use manufacturing, technology, and transport and logistics. Its first approved investment, in March 2026, was a Ukrainian drone-autonomy company, so agri-food investors should not count on it yet, although logistics investors may find it relevant.

World Bank-financed public projects are procured through competitive tenders. That means companies need to be registered and positioned before tenders are issued, not responding reactively after they appear. By the time a large-scale catering or food logistics contract is publicly tendered, the companies that will win it have already been building local relationships and compliance credentials for months.

VI. RISK ASSESSMENT

The Ukraine case carries seven main risks, and most can be managed through structure. The matrix below maps the main dimensions by probability and impact. Two of them, war continuity and corruption, require deeper treatment, and the 2026 port strikes justify a separate line for Black Sea logistics.

Risk	Probability	Impact	Mitigation
War continuation / renewed escalation	HIGH	CRITICAL	Asset-light entry; phased capital; political risk insurance (DFC / MIGA)
Black Sea port and logistics disruption	HIGH	HIGH	Route diversification (Danube, rail, road); phase capital into non-Odesa assets first
Corruption & governance failure	HIGH	HIGH	Strong local partner; legal due diligence; EBRD compliance framework
Reconstruction timeline delays	MEDIUM	MEDIUM	Staged investment; flexible contracts; milestone-linked payments
EU accession stalls or reverses	MEDIUM	HIGH	Build to EU standards regardless; diversify exit options
Commodity price normalisation	MEDIUM	MEDIUM	Long-term offtake agreements; currency hedging instruments
Reputational risk (conflict association)	LOW	MEDIUM	Clear ESG framing; humanitarian alignment in external communications

Table 3: Ukraine Investment Risk Matrix, Hospitality and Agri-Food Sector. Ratings are the author's judgement.

War continuation. This is the central constraint and it cannot be minimised. As of mid-September 2026 there is no ceasefire. US envoys held talks in Kyiv and Moscow in early September without a deal, Russia is demanding Ukrainian withdrawal from the rest of Donetsk and Luhansk, and Kyiv refuses (Al Jazeera, 2026). Security guarantees remain undefined. An investor committing capital to a food processing facility in central Ukraine in 2026 is accepting real exposure to continued destruction and renewed offensive operations, and to the possibility that the political situation deteriorates rather than improves. This is a high-risk, high-reward entry, and the test is whether the risk-adjusted return justifies it. For companies with the right structure and a long enough time horizon, the argument is that it does.

Corruption. Ukraine ranked 104th of 182 countries on Transparency International's 2025 Corruption Perceptions Index, with a score of 36 out of 100, one point above 2024. Anti-corruption reform in countries with deeply embedded patronage networks moves slowly regardless of political will. In practice, local partnerships matter more here than in most markets. Without a strong local partner that has political relationships and compliance experience, an operation can expect years of permitting delays, contract disputes and regulatory obstruction.

VII. STRATEGIC IMPLICATIONS

Hospitality is not a synonym for hotels. The sector encompasses the full chain from agricultural production through processing, logistics, catering, and food service. This paper's argument is grounded in that broader definition. The strategic implications below are written for companies operating anywhere along that chain, not only for hotel groups. The Ukraine reconstruction opportunity is primarily an agri-food and logistics opportunity, and hospitality groups are well placed to act on it.

Get in early and keep the structure light. The best entry is not equity-heavy. Joint ventures with established Ukrainian agricultural operators, management contracts for food processing facilities, and logistics partnerships with EU operators already active in Ukraine keep balance-sheet exposure low while positioning companies to benefit as the situation normalises. The operational value is captured while the local partner carries the asset risk.

Build the route before the plant. With Odesa's deep-water ports shut or under fire, Ukraine's agricultural council has told exporters to plan on the deep-water ports staying closed through December and January (Ag Bull, 2026), after shipowners suspended calls (Semafor, 2026). Capital that goes first into Danube, rail and border-crossing capacity serves both the war scenario and the peace scenario, and it is the best-supported logistics entry point today.

Focus on processing, not commodities. Ukraine does not need foreign capital to grow grain. It does that better than almost anyone. The gap is in what happens after harvest: processing, packaging, cold chain, branded consumer goods. That is where margins are highest and domestic industry is weakest, so it is where foreign companies add the most value.

Build to EU standards from day one. Ukraine's accession process will eventually bring EU food safety, labelling, and logistics standards into the domestic market. Companies that build to those standards now will integrate into European supply chains as accession advances. Companies that wait will have to retrofit. With Hungary still blocking parts of the accession process, the timeline is uncertain, which is one more reason to build to the standard now rather than wait for it to be imposed.

For hospitality groups specifically: enter through catering and food service, not hotels. The near-term vehicle for a hospitality operator is institutional catering and managed food service contracts tied to reconstruction programmes, not hotel development. A group with existing government contracting capability enters through a management contract or joint venture with a local catering operator, builds the client relationships and supply chain infrastructure during the reconstruction phase, and exits or scales into consumer-facing food service as the market normalises. The hotel opportunity comes later, once security conditions, property rights, and domestic consumer demand have stabilised. The sequencing matters: catering first, hospitality infrastructure second.

Track the reconstruction contract pipelines now. The World Bank, EBRD and EU are managing reconstruction financing at a scale not seen since the Marshall Plan, and the US-Ukraine Reconstruction Investment Fund is now operating alongside them. USAID, which was central to earlier US plans for private investment in Ukraine, ceased to operate as an independent agency in July 2025, so US-linked investors should look to DFC and the State Department instead. Hospitality companies with government contracting experience need to be monitoring procurement pipelines today. The contracts awarded in the next two to five years will define market positions for the decade after.

VIII. BEYOND UKRAINE: THE BROADER PATTERN

Ukraine is the most significant current case but it is not a one-off. The same dynamic, destruction followed by reconstruction-driven investment in essential food and logistics infrastructure, has appeared across modern post-conflict markets. Hospitality sector companies need the analytical and operational capacity to spot the next window before it closes. The cases below are best read as a watch-list rather than as open opportunities, because none has yet reached a settlement.

The Sahel is the nearest parallel in agricultural terms, but it is not post-conflict. Mali, Burkina Faso and Niger have been under military governments since 2020 to 2023 and remain in active insurgency. JNIM has run a fuel blockade in Mali since September 2025 and attacked several Malian cities in April 2026. The three states left ECOWAS in January 2025 and are turning to Russia and China, and the investment that has arrived is concentrated in mining and defence rather than agri-food (Security Council Report, 2026; FPRI,

2026). The conditions that define the Ukraine opportunity are only partly present: agricultural potential and minimal food processing infrastructure exist, but there is no security settlement and Western alignment is absent, which raises governance risk considerably and would change the entry structure required.

Myanmar is another case worth watching. Agriculture is central to its economy, and the 2021 military coup and continuing civil war have disrupted food supply chains and logistics. The junta held staged elections between December 2025 and January 2026, which a UN official called fraudulent, and Crisis Group describes the result as military consolidation rather than transition (Al Jazeera, 2026; Crisis Group, 2026). The FAO-WFP Hunger Hotspots outlook of June 2026 lists Myanmar among the places where conditions are expected to deteriorate. A reconstruction window would only open if political conditions change, and companies watching it should plan around that trigger rather than a date.

Gaza and Syria show the same pattern at the reconstruction-planning stage. The World Bank put Syria's reconstruction cost at over $216 billion in October 2025, after the EU and US eased sanctions. The joint Gaza assessment of April 2026 estimated needs of $71.4 billion over ten years (House of Commons Library, 2025; UN, 2026). Neither market has reached a point where food and logistics investment can be underwritten, but both are being sized by the same institutions that sized Ukraine.

The pattern across all of these markets is consistent. Post-conflict reconstruction creates a specific, time-limited entry window for the essential services layer of the hospitality sector. The window is defined by the gap between when financing starts flowing and when the market normalises and competition intensifies. In Ukraine that window is open but contested. In the other cases it has not yet opened. Companies that build the capability to operate in these environments, the risk management tools, the local partnership frameworks, and the government contracting experience, will enter each successive window faster and more effectively than competitors who treat every post-conflict market as a novel situation.

IX. CONCLUSION

Geopolitical instability destroys consumer-facing hospitality but creates conditions that favour investment in the sector's essential core. Ukraine has the most compelling combination of agricultural endowment, estimated reconstruction need, and Western alignment of any reconstruction market today. The comparison with post-WWII Germany and post-Soviet Poland is instructive, though imperfect, because the war has not ended and Germany's recovery owed less to Marshall aid than the popular account suggests. The entry window is open and it will not stay open indefinitely.

The risks are real. The war is not over, the Black Sea ports are under attack, corruption is a structural problem, and reconstruction timelines will not run smoothly. But companies that enter early, keep their structure light, build routes that do not depend on Odesa, and focus on food processing and logistics rather than hotels will be positioned to capture a first-mover advantage that lasts for years. Ukraine's reconstruction is the rebuilding of one of the world's most important food supply systems. The strategic opportunity for the hospitality industry is to invest first in agricultural processing, cold chain and logistics networks, which every hospitality operation depends on, and to leave hotels for later. The window is open, for structures that can survive the war continuing.

This paper was written as a portfolio research piece. All data and analysis draw on publicly available sources and reflect independent judgement. It does not represent the views of EHL Lausanne or any affiliated institution.

ANNEX: SOURCES & REFERENCES

All sources listed below are publicly available. Each link was opened and checked in September 2026. Sources marked (background) predate 2024 or are used for historical context only.

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